



A carving of the Buddha from Sarnath in North India, where a school of Buddhist art flourished under the Kushans.

IN INDIA, THE AREA CONTROLLED BY THE KUSHAN DYNASTY began to shrink after the death of King Kanishka in 140, and particularly severe territorial losses were suffered under Huvishka (r. 160–90). Kushan rule finally collapsed under Vasudeva (r. 190–225) when Persian invaders swept through northwestern India. Although Kushan kings continued to rule a much-reduced realm for a further century, their influence was purely local and their **heyday was at an end**.

In Rome, Caracalla's government was unpopular. Among his measures was the **Antonine Constitution of 212**, by

which citizenship was granted to almost all free males in the empire. After a successful campaign on the Rhine (in 213), Caracalla ventured further afield, arriving in Egypt in 215. For some unknown reason, he became enraged and ordered the **massacre** of the citizens of **Alexandria**. The next year he launched an invasion of Parthia. His praetorian prefect **Opellius Macrinus** came to suspect that Caracalla wanted him dead, so he persuaded a disaffected soldier to murder the emperor. After Caracalla's murder, **the army declared Macrinus emperor**. There was much residual loyalty

2,000 THE NUMBER OF BATHERS THAT COULD USE THE BATHS OF CARACALLA

to the Severan family, and a revolt broke out in Syria, which aimed to put **Elagabalus** (203–22), grandson of Julia Domna's sister Julia Maesa, on the throne. Macrinus lost support and in June 218 he fled to Cappadocia, where he was killed. In 221, Elagabalus **adopted as his heir** his cousin Alexianus. When the two fell out in 222, the army backed Alexianus and Elagabalus was murdered. Alexianus became **Emperor Alexander Severus** at age 13.

In Persia, Parthian rule had been weakened, both by plague and by the effects of successive Roman invasions. In 207, the kingdom had been

Bronze diploma

Diplomas were issued to auxiliary soldiers in the Roman army, granting them citizenship. This practice ceased after the Antonine Constitution.

Arch of Caracalla

Originally the arch was topped by a figure of the emperor riding in a chariot. It stands in Volubilis, the main town of Roman Mauretania Tingitana (in modern Morocco).



divided into two when Vologeses VI's brother set himself up as a rival king, **Artabanus V**; and a further Roman invasion in 216 ravaged much of the province of Media. Taking advantage of this disorder, the ruler of the southwestern province of Pars, **Ardashir**, expanded his territory and finally defeated Artabanus V c. 224. Ardashir I was then declared king (r. 224–42) as the **first ruler of the Sasanian dynasty**. Although

Persia was temporarily weakened by a civil war, the Sasanians proved to be **much tougher adversaries** to the Romans than the Parthians ever had been.

In China in 220, Cao Cao's son Cao Pi **forced Xiandi to abdicate**. Within two years Cao Pi, Liu Bei, and Sun Quan would each declare himself emperor. The **Han dynasty** and China's unity were at an end.



The Sasanian Empire in Persia

After rapidly acquiring the former Parthian Empire, the Sasanians fought a series of wars with the Romans over control of Mesopotamia.

KEY

- Sasanian Empire at greatest extent
- East Roman Empire in 3rd century

